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Review Essay



The Inquisitor and the Moseret: The Invention of Race in the European Middle Ages and the New English Colonialism in Jewish Historiography

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When I teach undergraduate classes on the Hebrew poetry of medieval Spain, my students and I spend a lot of time with Judah Halevi. Wildly polymathic, he is the most famous of the poets of his time and place and he is the one whose life we know the most about: letters and other documents have survived over eight centuries to record not only an extraordinary body of poetry but also his views on Jewish identity, his relationship with Jewish communities across the Mediterranean, and the longing for a Zion that has always been the stuff of legend.¹ He is one of those figures who, like Alexander the Great, is as much the product of his biographers' imagination as of his own.² He is, to borrow a turn of phrase from the King James Bible, all things to all men (1 Corinth. 9:22). Around 1125, he sent a letter to a confederate in the Fayūm dealing with two items of business: collecting a ransom for a Jewish girl kidnapped from her home in Castile during an outbreak of intercommunal

1 For an overview of Halevi's life, see Ross Brann, "Judah Halevi."

2 A notable recent example of this phenomenon is Hillel Halkin's autobiographically inflected biography of Halevi (*Yehuda Halevi*), although it dates back to the nineteenth century, when German scholars of the *Wissenschaft des Judentums*, such as Abraham Geiger (*Divan des Castiliens*), portrayed him as they saw themselves: an assimilated Jew who spoke and wrote in the language of culture.

violence and delivering a shipment of writing paper.³ In the second matter, he mentions that he will be sending 500 sheets that he obtained from a merchant. When I teach this letter, I hand my students a ream of copy paper that I took on long-term loan from my department's supply closet especially for this purpose; and I ask them to tell me what they can observe about this artifact of modern life in light of the letter we just read. I usually get some looks of incredulity as I appear to conclude a discussion on the taking and ransoming of prisoners with something as mundane as a pack of paper. As they circulate the object around the seminar table and read the label they eventually come to realize that a ream of paper, the standard, commercially saleable unit of measure, has comprised 500 sheets for nearly a millennium.⁴ This exercise fosters a kind of closeness in my students with historical and literary subjects who often seem very distant and alien to them; I want them to see that people who lived during the Middle Ages are, in many fundamental ways, more similar to people living now than they are dissimilar.

Judah Halevi elicits a lot of co-identification, both positive and negative, from my students. Often we read excerpts from Halevi's *Kuzari*, also known as *The Book of Proofs and Refutations in Defense of the Despised Faith*, a dialogue that contains, on the one hand, broad-minded Jewish philosophical principles that show intimate familiarity with both Islamic and Neo-Platonist thinking, and, on the other hand, a troubling argument for the inherent, biological superiority of Jews.⁵ Talking through the religious-historical background to the text with my students one semester, I mentioned that many of Halevi's ideas came from thinkers who belong to a Shiite Muslim group known as Ismā'īlī.⁶ One student's face lit up and she almost squeaked with delight as she exclaimed spontaneously to her classmates: "I am Ismā'īlī!" This suddenly forged personal connection gave her a guidewire through the text: a clear route to follow and one that she was motivated to hold fast by her curiosity about her own life and

3 ENA New Series 40, published in Gil and Fleischer, eds., *Judah Halevi and His Circle*. Translation and English-language discussion in Goitein, *A Mediterranean Society*, 5:448–68.

4 Goitein, "The Biography of Rabbi Judah Halevi," 49; Jonathan Bloom, *Paper Before Print*, 9.

5 Judah Halevi, *Kitāb al-Radd wa-l-dalīl fī l-dīn al-dhalīl*. A complete list of translations into English, German, and Hebrew is available via the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/halevi/> (accessed 6/2019).

6 The foundational study on the topic is Shlomo Pines, "Shiite Terms and Conceptions." More recently, see two interventions by Ehud Krinis: *God's Chosen People*, and "Galut and Ghayba." A concise overview of Ismā'īlī history and thought may be found in Farhad Daftary's *The Ismailis* and *A Modern History of the Ismailis*, and *A History of Shi'i Islam*. Forthcoming is a selection of Etan Kohlberg's studies on Shi'ite theology in a collected volume, *In Praise of the Few*. The mythology of Ismā'īlī assassins is covered in Daftary's *The Assassin Legend*. A classic work on the topic is Marshall Hodgson's *The Secret Order of Assassins*.

the intellectual life and history of her religious community; it afforded her a way to read with a focus and coherence that are sometimes hard for college students to achieve in medieval texts that are objectively difficult and that can seem so distant and alien to them. Later, as we discussed Halevi's development of the idea that Judaism was a kind of superiority transmitted by blood,⁷ another student spoke up, almost inaudibly and barely looking up from her notebook: "I just want to make it clear," she said, "that even though I'm Jewish I don't agree with this." When I suggested that she was not personally responsible for every idea ever held by one of her coreligionists, she replied: "Sometimes it feels like I am." In a political climate in which members of religious and racial minority groups are often asked to account for the views and actions of people who might look or pray like them but share little else in common, she wanted there to be no question: Judah Halevi was her brethren but not her fellow.⁸

More than any other figure, it has been Halevi who has helped my students come to terms with the complexity and familiarity of the medieval writers we meet in the course of a semester. Not only do the day-to-day details of his life ring true to them, he also grappled with big issues that are still current and relevant. Recently, and particularly in the wake of the Black Lives Matter protests steps away from our campus in Washington Square Park and the very public conversations about the consequences of racial difference in American civic life, it is Halevi's ideas about a racialized Jewish people that have compelled and appealed to my students. For example, contemporary political discourse

7 On which, see: Diana Lobel, *Between Mysticism and Philosophy*; and Daniel J. Lasker, "Proselyte Judaism."

8 This class session took place during the spring semester of 2014 as a part of my regular upper-division undergraduate seminar, "Islamic Spain: Literature and Society." Because I am opening this review essay with a personal reflection that includes experiences of students at my own university and ends with reflections upon the place of medieval studies in the modern world, it is perhaps worth mentioning that NYU is, at the time of this writing in the middle of 2019, experiencing some difficult moments of campus coexistence amongst students of the three Abrahamic faiths, particularly when it comes to discussion of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and study abroad in the Middle East. These tensions were not running as high or as publicly five years ago as they are now. Being a member of faculty affords me a position and experiences that are quite different than those of a typical undergraduate, but neither then nor now have I experienced the institution to be hostile or demanding of intellectual, political, or religious conformity; with that said it is clear that that a number of my students have felt that to be their experience. News coverage of and commentary upon these ongoing issues may be found in the NYU student press, the *NYU Local* and *Washington Square News*; in local and national publications, including the *New York Post*, *Wall Street Journal*, and *Newsweek*; and in Jewish publications including *Tablet* and *The Forward*. The present paper was already in proofs by the time of the worldwide Black Lives Matter protests following the homicide of George Floyd by Minneapolis police in May, 2020.

often racializes Islam,⁹ treating religious difference as inherent, inescapable, and biological. Articulating the idea that religious groups may be treated as racial categories by outside observers allows my students and colleagues as well as pundits, journalists, interested observers, and those Muslims who find themselves at the wrong end of religious discrimination to talk about Islamophobia as a kind of racism and to come up with productive strategies to fight against it. When a concept as seemingly modern as race appears in medieval materials it paradoxically offers a more comfortable arena—by virtue of its temporal distance and apparent foreignness—in which students, especially, can think through the issues and test out ideas that they can then take out into their own daily lives; it also shows them, again, that medieval people were not so different from themselves. While empathy can be a fallacious and destructive category of analysis, when it is not used as a substitute for critical analysis but rather to encourage it, I find that it can be useful in a classroom setting.¹⁰ Perhaps a better term for what I mean is *critical compassion*: this is not the trap of empathy, assuming that others experience the world in the same way or that these experiences can be rendered emotionally comparable; rather, it is an internalized, personal drive to use critical tools to come to a better personal understanding of the experience of another, whether in historical terms or not.¹¹ Fostering critical compassion is one way to spark curiosity

9 As we can see in Judah Halevi's writing, as well as in debates that occur within and between the work of other medieval theologians, jurists, and philosophers, including, for example, Moses Maimonides, the question of whether religious groups constitute a racial identity itself goes back to the Middle Ages. Theodore Vial opens his monograph, *Modern Religion, Modern Race*, with the declaration that "race and religion are conjoined twins" (1). (He goes on to qualify it by saying that "they are offspring of the modern world," though ultimately the framework he lays out provides some useful frameworks into which medieval materials, too, fit.) For more description, theorization, and examples of the phenomenon, see: Falungi Sheth, "The Racialization of Muslims in the Post-9/11 United States"; Steve Garner and Saher Selod, "The Racialization of Muslims"; and Steve Kaplan, "If There Are No Races, How Can Jews Be A Race?"

10 My use of the word *empathy* here will surely raise alarm bells for those scholars whose work is grounded in the body of critical race theory, a foundational concept of which is the "empathic fallacy," described by Richard Delgado and Jean Stefancic as "the belief that one can change a narrative by merely offering another better one, and that the reader's sympathy will quickly and reliably take over" (33); however, as the rest of this discussion indicates, I am not using it as a substitute for critical analysis but rather as an impetus to pursue it. This balance between empathy and criticism in a classroom setting is addressed in Michael Warner, "Uncritical Reading."

11 Here, I am following the work of psychologist Paul Bloom and of moral philosophers such as Martha Nussbaum, who likewise discourage the use of empathy as a critical category but offer possible substitutes that can account for curiosity, morality, and other selected component parts of empathy. See Paul Bloom, *Against Empathy*.

and a drive to research in those who are learning those skills, and an approach that can continue motivate those who are already years immersed in a topic to pursue the new and the ethical. Although it might not be the first thing that comes to mind when defining the methodological parameters of a project, critical compassion has an important role to play in a scholar's toolkit, and in a student's. And although a drive toward viewing the medieval through a lens of critical compassion may originate in classical-liberal notions of property, that language can be deployed to prioritize and value the identities of the subjects under study: "The emphasis on treating each person with 'concern and respect' reflects the new prominence given to the translation of 'property' as an essential dimension of individual identity ... because treating someone with concern and respect presupposed a recognition of that person's being an owner of who and what they are—their 'identity.'"¹² To pursue an understanding of the Middle Ages through the lens of critical compassion is both intellectually rigorous and supremely humane.

Halevi is a thinker whose body of work demonstrates that medieval people categorized themselves and others along racial lines, even as some contemporary scholars have claimed and continue to claim that race is necessarily and exclusively a modern concept. His development of the concept of the *ṣafwah* of the Jewish people, their biologically inherent, blood-transmissible chosenness and consequent superiority, is a clear example of race-making.¹³ As early as the mid-20th century Halevi's readers were aware that race was an operative category in his philosophical and theological writings, one that could be ripe for anthropological and proto-race-critical analysis. Cedric Dover, whose views on race were shaped in part by his childhood in British colonial India, his adulthood classified as a "coloured" man in Britain, and as a participant in and out of W.E.B. Du Bois's intellectual circle in the United States, was particularly interested in the systems of racial classification that grew up in the medieval Islamic world.¹⁴ In a short 1952 essay he wrote that in Halevi's work "we see definite signs of the aggravated nationalism which is now called 'racialism.' This development of tribal thinking was not new even in Halevi's day, but he raised the existing ethnic mystiques to the level of carefully constructed appeals to reason."¹⁵ He further observes that this in no way makes Halevi an exception amongst his peers in the Arabo-Islamic world:

12 Talal Asad, "Secular Equality and Religious Language," 28–9.

13 On the nature of *ṣafwah* and its emergence from Shiite thought, see Krinis, *God's Chosen People*.

14 Nico Slate. *The Prism of Race*.

15 Cedric Dover, "The Racial Philosophy of Judah Halevi," 318.

Neither Halevi nor Jews “invented” racialism; and it is equally easy to appreciate the materials they provide for a cooperative, developmental knowledge of the operative factors in racialism. Essentially, Halevi’s philosophy, with its suggestive blend of mysticism, nationalism, and racism, is thereby revealed as a direct response to minority status and conflicting monotheistic interests. The romantic view, associated with its claims to priority amongst the ethnocentric mystiques of the Middle Ages, gives it colour but no added significance.¹⁶

Although he necessarily writes using the nomenclature of his age rather than the vocabulary of later critical race theory, Dover signals that Halevi is the case study par excellence to show that race-qua-race as we understand it today is indeed an idea that may be found in the Middle Ages, and is one that is always shaped by the discourses that surround it. On the one hand, like modern scholars do, Halevi fundamentally understands that a religion can be racialized; on the other hand, he wields that knowledge in a way that is antithetical to me and to my students. He has the same questions as his modern readers who populate the college classrooms I know best, but comes to very different conclusions than they do, as my student indicated with her insistence that her classmates know explicitly that she was not in agreement with him in spite, as Halevi would have had it, her “faith in the God of Abraham.”¹⁷

I turned to read Geraldine Heng’s recently-published *The Invention of Race in the European Middle Ages*, and in particular its chapters on the representation and racialization of the Muslims and Jews of medieval Europe, in part because many of my colleagues in Medieval Studies have lauded the book as a paradigm-shifting must-read and in part in the hopes of coming to a better understanding of the broad theoretical questions that I regularly confront in reading and teaching Halevi as they play out in other parts of Europe. I didn’t expect to find a direct answer to my Halevi questions, but instead hoped that the volume would offer new insights to bring to my teaching of race and religion in medieval Spain and leading-edge methodologies for doing so. It is a book for whose success I was rooting because the topic of race and race-making in history is so timely and necessary; but ultimately I found myself let down both by the book and by the hubbub surrounding its publication. Instead of offering a model of critical compassion towards its subjects that allows the reader to analyze and understand them without the imposed structures of colonial and

16 Dover, “The Racial Philosophy of Judah Halevi,” 322. See also his “The Racial Philosophy of Ibn Khaldun.”

17 Judah Halevi. *The Kuzari* 1:11.

white supremacist historiography, the volume's treatment of medieval Jews and Muslims makes it one more work of history written through the eyes of the legal, ecclesiastical, and textual hegemonies of a Christian Middle Ages and its modern academic heirs. In other words, the book fails on its own terms in that even while it foregrounds the racialization of religious minorities and advocates for the decolonization of medieval scholarship, the author in effect adopts of the voice of her medieval English Christian interlocutors as her own, giving voice and power not to the religious subaltern but to the unmarked majority population whose perspectives form normative ideas about medieval race. On the surface of it this may seem to be an off-base critique of a book that is about the representation of these populations and their categorization from without rather than their self-conceptualization. However, the heart of the problem is this: it is not that Heng presents the literature and history of race-making in medieval England as carried out by the medieval English; rather, it is that in her critical vocabulary, choice of sources, and framing of problems, she herself is unable to escape that medieval mode of thought and, therefore, cannot fully analyze or critique it because it is embedded in and constitutive of her own work and informs and guides the perspective from which she approaches and interrogates the material.

1 Overview

The Invention of Race responds to the contention made in some scholarship that race is a modern concept and is consequently not a valuable interpretive cipher for the study of non-modern¹⁸ literatures, cultures, and societies. Heng sets out the *raison d'être* of the project in terms of recent historiography when she writes:

In 2008, medievalists in general were not convinced that the concept of race had any purchase for the medieval period. Race theorists also deemed the project presentist, convinced that race was a modern phenomenon and that they could safely ignore the Middle Ages, which they

18 Non-modern is the term that José Rabassa coined to designate everything earlier than the modern period, breaking down artificial boundaries between the medieval and the early modern in his "Decolonizing Medieval Mexico." Although space and an attempt at thematic coherence dictate that I will not be able to delve into the temporal element of postcolonial theory, it would be worth in another context to consider some of the continuities of race-making between the traditionally construed medieval and early modern periods that a periodization of "non-modernity" facilitates.

saw as a prepolitical era with scant relevance for the cultures of modernity that followed, and thus a period of little interest to them. It became clear that race needed to be understood differently from its definition by canonical twentieth-century race theories, and in ways apposite to the medieval past, for medievalists and race theorists to be willing to look at the past anew.¹⁹

In order to achieve these goals of increasing the awareness of how race operated in the non-modern world and introduce new theoretical approaches to the academic study of the Middle Ages, the volume begins with a useful working definition drawn from the cultural-anthropological work of Ann Laura Stoler: "Race is a structural relationship for the articulation and management of human differences, rather than a substantive content."²⁰ And crucially in a field that is sometimes quick to dismiss the role of religion or to disentangle it too easily from other mechanisms of medieval culture, Heng includes religion as one of the important medieval categories of difference that can be racialized;²¹ even though Heng's execution of this analysis lacks both the depth and nuance of scholarship that takes the history of religions as a more central focus, the mere fact of addressing the possibilities of religion in this way is not ordinary and not new but nor is it widespread, and so represents a strong point of the work.

19 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 3.

20 The complete definition offered is as follows: "'Race' is one of the primary names we have—a name we retain for the strategic, epistemological, and political commitments it recognizes—that is attached to a repeating tendency, of the gravest import, to demarcate human beings through differences among humans that are selectively essentialized as absolute and fundamental, in order to distribute positions and powers differentially to human groups. Race-making thus operates as specific historical occasions in which strategic essentialisms are posited and assigned through a variety of practices and pressures, so as to construct a hierarchy of peoples for differential treatment. My understanding, thus, is that race is a structural relationship for the articulation and management of human differences, rather than a substantive content" (*The Invention of Race*, 3, 27, and in part on 19; emphasis in original). Although this definition is central to the volume, both its repetition verbatim in several places and the heavy-handed, seemingly random, and ultimately distracting italicization decisions (here and throughout the volume) suggest that the work was perhaps not edited as carefully as it might have been).

21 "Moreover, in addressing the nested discourses formative of race in the European Middle Ages, it was particularly important to note that religion—the paramount source of authority in the medieval period—could function both socioculturally and biopolitically: subjecting peoples of a detested faith, for instance, to a political theology that could biologize, define, and essentialize an entire community as fundamentally and absolutely different in an inter-knotted cluster of ways" (27). In this respect, Heng builds upon earlier work by Suzanne Conklin Akbari (*Idols in the East*) on the racialization of Islam and Muslims in the European Middle Ages.

The book's theoretical foundations are located in postcolonial and critical race theory, both of which are by now well-established approaches to medieval material, if not accepted across the board. Although it may seem anachronistic to the uninitiated to take a postcolonial approach to the study of a pre-colonial world, that is not, in fact, the case. Because modern Medieval Studies grew up, as a field, alongside the European nationalist movements of the nineteenth century, many of the national, the imperial and the colonial attitudes of that time and place are embedded within the methodologies of the field.²² To decolonize the Middle Ages refers to excising this inherent colonial episteme and instead attempting to approach the material without that particular intellectual and cultural baggage. In the case of *The Invention of Race*, this decolonization ostensibly functions by stripping away the nineteenth-century European ideas about race read into medieval sources and looking instead at how medieval Europeans imagined race and racial categories for themselves. Chapter by chapter, the volume attempts to unpack examples of race-making in the medieval world by showing how those categorizations function both in terms of their own internal logic and the ways they were brought to bear in the real world. The first chapter introduces the reader to critical race theory and the implications of racial categorization both in the present day and on a historical scale. It offers a selective review of some of the previous work on race and race-making in the ancient and medieval worlds. The second chapter focuses on the Jews of England as an internal minority population and the ways in which that population was represented in literature and treated in history consequent to that racialized representation. The third chapter focuses on the creation and deployment of the figure of the "Saracen" in complex representations of medieval Muslims, mostly but not exclusively in the English literary context. Chapter four explicates the difference between what Heng terms "hermeneutic" race and "physiognomic" or "epidermal" race,²³ that is to say, the difference between an individual being considered black or white in a social context rather than actually having a skin color that could be defined as white rather than pinkish or black rather than brownish. With this distinction in mind, the chapter explores the ways in which representations of people with dark skin developed over time and came to have negative characteristics accrete to them within an English and Christian context. Chapters five and six look beyond medieval Europe to North America and Central Asia to situate these ideas within

22 For various overviews of and approaches to this phenomenon, see the introductions to Nadia Altschul, *Geographies of Philological Knowledge*; Jeffrey Jerome Cohen, ed. *The Postcolonial Middle Ages*; and Ananya Jahanara Kabir and Deanne Williams, eds. *Postcolonial Approaches to the European Middle Ages*.

23 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 185.

a more global Middle Ages, a framing that seeks to build upon the work by earlier scholars but, in the end, is more illustrative of the limitations of studying a truly global Middle Ages when looking out at the globe with one's feet planted firmly in England.²⁴

Ultimately, even though Heng "emphasized multiple locations of race over a single epidermal focus: framing out how religion, the state, economic interests, colonization, war, and international contests for hegemony [that] have materialized race and have configured racial attitudes, behavior, and phenomena across the centuries,"²⁵ the volume is insufficient in its treatment of those foci. To the literary critic or cultural historian of Judaism and Islam in their medieval European contexts, it is the book's recourse to Christian language and dependence upon Christian theological and cultural structures as the lens through which to read the racialization of Islam and Judaism that trouble, demand attention, and perhaps suggest that some of the hagiographic response to the volume is misplaced except from the perspective of the Christians of medieval England themselves and their historians.²⁶ In spite of the promise of attention to religion as a racializable category in the medieval period, it is instead painted in broad strokes and with real gaps in coverage and many outright mistakes. In the end, rather than dismantling the language and ideology of the Christian societies that racialized their Jewish and Muslim minorities, she adopts it wholesale.

The rest of this essay will demonstrate that *The Invention of Race* is a master class in how not to write about the racialization of religious groups; in Heng's case, her inattentiveness and critical carelessness ultimately lead to the reproduction of the colonial episteme that is, only ostensibly and ultimately superficially, being critiqued in her work. It has potential to cause real damage to the study of Jews and Muslims in the Middle Ages by promoting regressive views dressed up in the language of theory and addressed to an audience that is at

24 Janet Abu-Lughod. *Before European Hegemony*. For a brief overview of the rise of "global history" in the late 1980s and early 1990s, see the introduction and first chapter of Sebastian Conrad's *What is Global History?* Many scholars of medieval English literature have attributed much of this "global turn" in Medieval Studies to Heng herself, although there is, of course, a body of precedent work on a more globalized Middle Ages.

25 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 181.

26 Representative of the response of the scholars of medieval English literature to the volume is Shyama Rajendran's recent review which praises the clarity of Heng's writing and the comprehensiveness of her bibliography, neither a characterization of the book with which I agree; instead, I find the bibliography to be eclectic and the writing style needlessly high-academic. The place where I very much agree with Rajendran is when she expresses her "wish" that the book "should have been more than one volume. As a reader, one inevitably wants more depth from chapters that are designed to deliver breadth" (481).

once hungry for a good treatment of the subject and not equipped, by virtue only of the limits of disciplinary training, to pull out the good while rejecting the careless. It argues, in turns deliberately and by negative example, for the necessity of good, solid, interdisciplinary work, the former by laying out the case for it and the latter by illustrating the consequences of not following through. Doing this well matters and the stakes are both medieval and modern.

I will limit the bulk of my comments to chapter two, the one that focuses on race-making in the case of England's Jews; the single chapter offers enough material, while limiting the scope of the review allows for a thorough discussion that is representative of my reading of the book as a whole.²⁷ My own expertise as a scholar means that I was most interested in and qualified to engage with the issues raised in Heng's the discussions of Judaism and Islam; and ultimately I wanted to walk through a single chapter in detail rather than describing the problematic aspects of the work in broader strokes that could cover the entire work, although there are many ways in which one could approach and frame a critique of this volume. Everything I say about Heng's treatment of the racialization of Jews also holds for her treatment of the racialization of Muslims and, at least to a certain extent, the other groups of Others discussed in the volume; I will address highlights of the latter case in the notes.

2 The Jews of England in the Language of England

The foundation of *The Invention of Race* rests upon the notion that medieval England is an archetypal home for Jewish life in the Middle Ages which gives way to archetypal treatment and representation of Jews by Christians:

England's treatment of Jews has been described by Robert Stacey as "archetypal" of the countries of western Europe, with England's Jewish minority having many parallels in Jewish communities elsewhere. The

27 An intermediate draft of this essay also tackled the third chapter and its representation of Muslims, but in the interest of space and the ability to work in depth and detail, I ultimately decided to limit my analysis to chapter two. This is simply to say that the critiques made here of Heng's treatment of Jews and their representation in medieval English literature also hold for her treatment of Muslims. Shortly before the present review essay went to press, Shokoofeh Rajabzadeh published an essay combining personal reflection upon and critical analysis of the ways in which the term "Saracen" persists in contemporary scholarship on medieval English literature, practices that are wildly different from those employed in the contemporary study of medieval Mediterranean and Near Eastern literatures.

English example is thus at once situation-specific *and* resonant; and an analysis of English particularities may yield insights for those who would extend case-by-case studies of medieval race to other countries of Europe, carefully accounting for local differences and variations. The history of England's Jews, as scholars have shown, is exceptional principally by virtue of the earliness, speed, and intensity of the racializing process exhibited on English shores, and remarkable mainly for the inventiveness and energy that was dedicated to the panoply of race-making mechanisms delivered.²⁸

In other words, Heng is arguing, on the basis of Robert Stacey's work, that although it does not map fully onto other communities of European Jews in the Middle Ages, England is an archetype for Jewish life in Europe and is thus a sound choice as a case study from which to extrapolate her search for origins.²⁹ However, the idea that medieval England is archetypal is not widely accepted in Jewish historiography; and furthermore, Heng does not represent fully or accurately the scholarship she deploys to make her claim that the archetype holds. Stacey does indeed open his article by writing that

The Jews of medieval England were, in many respects, an archetypal medieval Ashkenazic community ... English Jews do exemplify the structural characteristics of Ashkenazic life to an extraordinary degree and in exaggerated ways. At the same time, their historical experience mirrors general developments in Jewish-Christian relations in dramatic fashion. Together, these observations lend to English Jewish history an interest and importance incommensurate with the tiny number of medieval English Jews. As a case study in Christian-Jewish relations during the twelfth century, they can scarcely be bettered.³⁰

However, this particular excerpt does not represent the totality of Stacey's argument. After posing exceptionality as a kind of intellectual exercise, he goes on to argue against it, only to draw his article to a close with somewhat more nuance, challenging the very notion of archetype itself:

28 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 58. Emphasis in the original.

29 The search for origins of religious and religion-adjacent phenomena in general has been critiqued as a kind of intellectual provincialism by David Nirenberg, as in a plenary lecture delivered at UCLA in the fall of 2018: "The Hybrid History of Conversion and Race in Christianity and Islam."

30 Stacey, "Jews and Christians," 340.

Structurally and culturally, Anglo-Jewry was indeed typical of many other Ashkenazi communities of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. It was also, in important ways, quite exceptional. But what I really want to argue for this the historical contingency, even the unpredictability, of the history of the Jews in medieval England. That history did not have to turn out the way it did. It took a decisive turn between 1144 and 1194. Yet there are undeniable parallels between the changes that took place in England at this time and those occurring in other Ashkenazic communities. By all means, then, let us search for models; and let us recognize clearly how formative for medieval Jewish experience in Europe the last half of the twelfth century truly was. But in doing so, let us not lose sight of the particularity of experience that characterized those differing communities. There may not be a history of the Jews in medieval Ashkenaz.³¹

Stacey is not, in the end, arguing that the Jewish community of medieval England is an archetypal European one, but rather that the dynamic relationship between Jews and Christians in that time and place paved the way for specific and determined internal and external changes in that community relative to its European counterparts. And indeed, scholarship in the twenty years since Stacey published this article has by and large rejects the idea of England's Jews as an archetype for Europe's. The current state of the question is based on the analysis of many factors, including the relative lateness of the arrival of Jews in England compared with the rest of Europe, the brevity of their communal life there, their evident lack of linguistic assimilation, and the necessary, relative insularity of these island communities. By holding up England as the archetype, Heng's book replicates an epistemological problem common in English literary study and in the field of Medieval Studies more broadly: namely treating England as European civilization's ground zero; for a notionally global book, this is a peculiar assumption to make and highlights some of the problems with a move toward a more "global" Medieval Studies, namely that it is not truly global, but rather represents scholars of England peering out at the rest of the world.³² The reader of this work must proceed through the volume knowing not only that it does not live up to its own theoretical goals, but more importantly that it is presenting an exceptional case as a pan-European

31 Stacey, "Jews and Christians," 351.

32 One of the places where this assumption is most evident and most likely to perpetuate this perception of England as the heart of the European Middle Ages to a wider audience is in the formulation of Elaine Treharne's *Very Short Introduction to Medieval Literature* (Oxford) which is, in fact, a very short introduction to medieval English literature only.

template for race-making in the medieval Jewish experience and, what's more, that the author's representation of her sources is not necessarily to be trusted; other examples of Heng mischaracterizing source material are identified and discussed elsewhere in the present essay.

Just as it may be easy for the English medievalist to mistake England for a place that is a universal cradle for Jewish lives and afterlives in medieval European societies, so, too, is it easy to mistake English for a universal and, crucially, neutral language in which to describe and analyze it; but it is not. The English language as it is used as the predominant academic koine is peppered with stock phrases and dead metaphors that originated in the King James Bible and came to be a part of the common parlance.³³ And so, in ways large and small, deliberate and reflexive, academic English is a language refracted through Christian theology. It is a mere fact of this tool of our trade. We live in a fundamentally Christian society, where even the default position of post-Enlightenment secularity is still undergirded by a Christian world view.³⁴ Thus, for a decolonial project in which religion is implicated, the framing of the work must interrogate the religiously inflected language that creates that world, and it is a task that Heng has overlooked in this work.³⁵ By failing to address this fundamental task, the author allows the Christian underpinnings of academic English to inf(lect) the tenor of her discourse; but of even greater consequence, she carelessly adopts the more explicitly polemical anti-Jewish language of her medieval subjects to write about medieval Jews.

A particularly attention-grabbing example of this phenomenon comes when Heng casts this process of Jewish conversion to Christianity in medieval

33 For examples, see "Phrases from the King James Bible."

34 In the first pages of his essay "Secular Equality," Talal Asad offers an overview of the ways in which secularization has been explicitly constructed as an ideological emanation of Christian values; he goes on in the rest of the essay to challenge this connection and explore the ways in which the vocabularies of liberalism, religion, and secularity are mutually constitutive. Jonathan Decter has written recently in the *Marginalia Review of Books* about the centrality of philology to the project of comparative religious history insofar as it allows for a more organic analysis of what the academy itself terms the category of religion: "... we can better analyze the thought categories of pre-modern people when we allow their language to speak for itself. Getting at the precise meaning of words—the semantic fields to which they belong—is an essential starting point for such a project and a place where high theory and philology converge."

35 This necessity is made clear in Jonathan Z. Smith's widely read and cited essay, "Religion, Religions, Religious," reprinted most recently in his volume of collected essays, *Relating Religion*. Smith opens his essay by laying out the originals in the English and Spanish colonial projects of designating certain praxes as religions and then demonstrates that, like race, "religion" (rather than Judaism, Islam, or Christianity) is a category that is formed and imposed from the outside and always delineated in external, observed terms.

England within a christological chronotope³⁶ by drawing upon the language of the New Testament to frame the chronology of the conversion process, explaining that it happens “in the fullness of time”; here she borrows the phrase from the New Testament book of Galatians (4:4–7) that is used to describe the inevitability of Jesus’ intervention in history as the Christ as far as ecclesiastical history is concerned. One might be inclined to think of the use of this phrase in this context as a kind of *lapsus calami*, a careless use of a phrase that has become common parlance in the English language. But whatever the cause—sloppiness or intentionality—its effect is to contextualize the history of Jewish conversion to Christianity within a Christian messianic and eschatological telos. As European medievalists, even European medievalists with a global perspective, the biblical text is a foundational substratum for a great many of the sources that we read and the contexts in which they were written and in which we read them; professionally, then, we have a responsibility to have some familiarity with the text, its impact on the language in which we write about our medieval subjects, and the consequences of adopting its language as our own. In this case, situating the conversion of Jews in a Christian messianic timeframe leverages Jews in the service of an eschatology that would instrumentalize them for the end times does not serve to decolonize the theology of representation in play; rather, it reifies it. And lined up with other examples of Christian-default language and perspective that form part of the critical approach of the book, delineated below, it appears as part of a pattern with a particular ideological bent rather than as an isolated mistake.

One of the consequences of Heng’s adoption of medieval biblicizing, exegetical, and polemical language to try to describe the racialization and persecution of Jews in the context of the First Crusade is to pit Jewish history against Islamic history; in her analysis, Heng inadvertently makes her Jewish subjects of inquiry into a theological instrument in Christendom’s fight against Islam.³⁷

36 On the significance of the temporal dimension of postcolonial criticism, and in medieval materials in particular, see Kathleen Biddick, *Periodization and Sovereignty*; Carolyn Dinshaw, *How Soon is Now?*; and the introduction and first chapter of Matthew X. Vernon, *The Black Middle Ages*.

37 Another First Crusade textual issue that emerges is Heng’s treatment of Pope Urban II’s call to Crusade at Clermont in 1095. Even though the volume from which she cites the text contains all five of the recorded versions of the speech, she does not acknowledge any of the textual issues that are crucially important both historically and in terms of the literary and memorious representation of the speech: The text is famously recorded in five distinct versions written after the fact. Some of the recorders of the speech may have been present, and several of the versions are at least partially textually interdependent; but ultimately all are radically different from each other. Or, as Matthew Gabriele quips in an essay written for a popular audience: “Pope Urban II stepped up onto a rostrum in

In the course of a discussion about the ways in which religion was understood in the Middle Ages to inhere in the blood and thus to form a biological basis by which religio-races were constituted, Heng describes the Crusaders' sanguinary arrival into Jerusalem in 1099 by citing and commenting on a few contemporaneous chronicles. Among these is the *History of Jerusalem* by Fulcher of Chartres, a cleric and chronicler of the First Crusade. Summarizing Fulcher's description of the scene Heng writes: "Fulcher estimated that 'ten thousand were beheaded' at the Temple of Solomon."³⁸ While she is clearly reflecting the language that Fulcher himself uses to describe the site, there is something troubling about her uncommented adoption of his name for the place that is sacred to the three Abrahamic faiths, where the Temple of Solomon was definitively destroyed by Romans in the year 70 of the Common Era, and where the Dome of the Rock and al-Aqsa Mosque complex was erected over the abandoned site at the orders of the Umayyad caliph 'Abd al-Mālik in the year 691. Fulcher calls that place the Temple of Solomon to invoke the Jewish-as-pre-Christian history of the place at the expense of the history of the Muslims who, by the time the Crusaders sacked the city, had worshipped in a shrine on that location for four centuries. By naming the site in Jewish terms, Fulcher is in fact placing a supersessionist and Christian claim upon it.³⁹ And by repeating rather than critiquing or offering an alternative to Fulcher's toponymy, Heng invokes that Christian interpretation of Jewish history, effectively marshaling its

a field outside the cathedral and said ... something." See Matthew Gabriele, "How One Speech Started a Medieval Holy War." However, Heng treats the call to Crusade as if it were a single, unitary text that exists in a historically agreed-upon version. She cites three of the versions in her footnotes, but does not ever render her choices about this legible and leaves the body of the text in such a vague state that a non-specialist reader would not realize that there are multiple and contested versions of the text. When a scholar makes the choice to elide dramatic differences in textual versions without even acknowledging that choice, it is hard to rely upon her presentation of analysis as truly reflective of the material. In other words, this kind of decision casts doubt on Heng's presentation of every other text and places the onus upon the reader to follow up and verify before even engaging with her arguments. To describe the book as borderline unusable on these grounds is not too far of an exaggeration; even setting aside the work's analysis, the merest presentation of both primary and secondary sources cannot be trusted. Abundant scholarship of Urban II and the Council of Clermont may be found referenced in Tomaz Mastnak, "Urban II."

38 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 123. It is unusual for a scholarly book to rely upon citations from an abridged, translated, teaching edition of Fulcher's chronicle, as Heng's work does here.

39 In his transhistorical survey of the sacking of Jerusalem, *Jerusalem Besieged*, Eric Cline writes about the power of the destroyed temple as a symbol of Christian providence during late antiquity (138); later, it featured prominently in various Crusader chronicles playing a similar role (175). See also Tamar Boyadijan, *The City of Lament*.

theological argument against Islam and Muslims' claims to the site just as her Crusade-apologist subject did.⁴⁰ This, in spite of the fact that she is fully aware of the colonial potentialities of Fulcher's positions and rhetoric, as evidenced when she subsequently writes:

Reading Fulcher now with the unavoidable knowledge of later, newer colonizations—accruing different moments of the colonial now—makes us alive to the modernity of the past, to the panoply of resources that can be amassed to mystify operations of power, and to the sheer parsimony and resilience of colonial dialect.⁴¹

In other words, Heng notes that, to the modern reader, Fulcher's observations about the sack of Jerusalem foreshadow subsequent conquests of the former

40 Not only does Heng adopt Christian terminology that reflected general theological consensus during the Middle Ages, but she also adopts it when it reflects the views of a small minority of medieval Catholics. One example of this comes in her brief discussion of the Córdoba martyrs' crisis, a ninth-century anomaly in which a group of young Mozarab Christians in Córdoba actively sought martyrdom at the instigation of a local Catholic cleric. Heng writes: "Even in contact zones, strategies of accommodation and creative acculturations among populations of unequal status living together cheek-by-jowl did not mean freedom from eruptions of violence, or from the sudden resumption of war. Where enemies live intimately in consort, stitching together mutual coexistence daily, peace is shadowed by violence. One lesson that issues from the spectacle of the so-called Martyrs of Córdoba in Umayyad-ruled Andalusia of 850–9, when some fifty Christians were executed, most at their own instigation, by order of the *qadi* of Córdoba is that *too much* acculturation—through interfaith marriage and sexual reproduction, linguistic adoptions, cultural mimicry, and stylistic adaptations—elicits violent response as a radical effort by some in the local populace (in this case, those who sought self-martyrdom) to etch clearer and more determinate identity boundaries between populations in close contact" (123, emphasis the author's). Yet in spite of Heng's portrayal of this situation as one in which latent hostilities boil over, the major take-away of the martyrs' crisis is that at that moment in Córdoba, Christians and Muslims were mostly *not* enemies; it is because of that historical reality that the would-be Christian martyrs had to work so hard over such an extended period of time to be transgressive enough to warrant being put to death. In other words, when Heng writes in her own voice about enemies living in close contact, she is not representing any broad medieval position on interfaith relations that was relevant in that time and place; rather, she joins the extremist Eulogius of Córdoba in calling Muslims the enemy of the local Christian population. For more on this episode, see Jessica Coope, *The Martyrs of Córdoba*; and Kenneth Baxter Wolf, *Christian Martyrs in Muslim Spain*. More generally, see Ann Christys, *Christians in al-Andalus*, and Christian Sahner, *Christian Martyrs Under Islam*. It is also worth identifying the source of the framework of the "contact zone," which goes uncredited in the volume: Mary Louise Pratt, "Arts of the Contact Zone."

41 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 126.

Aelia Capitolina and cannot, knowing what we now know, but prefigure the idea of that city as a colonial possession; similarly she describes Fulcher as a participant in a colonial state as its chronicler when she writes of his “ability to see ethnoracial variety among the eastern Christian women married to crusader colonists.”⁴² Yet all the same, she allows Fulcher’s hegemonic language to stand and to supersede the Jewish history that she claims to be decolonizing, at the expense of the Islamic history that was unfolding during his lifetime.

In the section “Conversion as Racial Passing and Strategic Essentialism,”⁴³ Heng reviews the bodily consequences of conversion from Judaism both as they took place in history (such as in the relocation of Jews to Henry III’s *domus conversorum*, an interstitial space which Heng characterizes merely as “odd”⁴⁴) and in imagination (such as the question of what happened to the supposed distinctive odor of Jews after they converted), and what these consequences can show about the idea of Judaism as a racial category in medieval England. She contends that “decades after a conversion, and even when the convert was a prominent personage—showered with protective privileges by the king, and decorated with the belt of knighthood—a residue of Jewishness would cling tenaciously, to trouble a convert’s Christian identity and stir up doubts about him.”⁴⁵ Her analysis of the consequences of this impossible-to-complete transition is superficial at best, as when she describes as “cruel” the appointment of William of Oxford, a formerly Jewish convert to Christianity, as tax collector; she leaves it at that single adjective rather than exploring the dynamics of conversion and taxation within and without the Jewish community as an issue of boundary-marking and money. The topic of moneylending, interest, and accusations of usury, which ironically happens to be one of the places in which English Jews’ experience most closely mirrors that of other northern European Jewish communities, is so potentially fruitful an arena in which to develop thought and argument about the racialization and racialized representation of Jews, but Heng does not follow through. This is a regular rhetorical move in the book that leaves the reader guessing, frustrated, and wanting more from the work: There are so many hints in this volume of moments in literature and history that could yield incredibly rich discussions about the creation of racial categories; one of its great strengths is in identifying many such examples. Yet they are repeatedly dropped as quickly as they are mentioned, without explanation and without ever being developed into a full or coherent

42 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 111.

43 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 75–81.

44 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 76.

45 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 76.

argument. Heng writes in the introduction about struggling with the length of the final product,⁴⁶ but her writerly solution of suggestion and moving on is not as rewarding or productive as offering fewer examples more thoroughly explicated, or tighter editing of the often-repetitive prose to free up space for further discussion, might have been.

This is particularly true when short-hand leads to an over-reliance on the language of the Church and the English state to try but fail to do the work of decolonizing the history of a racialized religious minority population, which returns us to the first issue noted above. Perhaps due in part to lack of space in which to reflect upon the tools of her trade, Heng continues to adopt explicitly Christian language as the ostensibly neutral, secular-academic base for her argument about religious conversion and its consequences for race-making; in other words, she is using both medieval and modern language that is inflected by the very perspective that constructs the imagined subject in the Middle Ages.

As in her analysis of Fulcher's vision of the sacred history of Jerusalem, Heng continues to ally herself with the medieval Christian perspective of her sources. In the course of a discussion on the ability of minorities and converts to "pass" in a majority society she comments:

If epistemological certainty is elusive, ontological certainty is also elusive, thanks to the inscrutability and interiority of the conversion process. Morrison's fine insight that conversion is, in fact, really a process, not a sudden cataclysmic change, in theory holds out hope for converts from Judaism: In due course, the progressivist logic of conversion momentum should allow for the completion of that process, at the end of a perhaps arduous trajectory, so that the convert arrives, in the fullness of time, at a culminating identity acceptable to all.⁴⁷

The language of hope and acceptability in this passage, as well as the idea of conversion first as a matter of interior belief only rather than adherence to community norms, orthopraxy, and participation in a particular legal system, and second as a process that can be or regularly is completed, betrays this project as one that studies ideas about Judaism and Islam by adhering to the reigning Christian hegemony that treats a common Anglophone culture as the unquestionably neutral default position in two ways: in its use of Christological

46 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 2–3.

47 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 79.

and eschatological language and in the perspective it reflects about the outcomes of religious conversion.

Even as the volume acknowledges the “inordinate danger” in which English Jews found themselves because of their “assigned role of inferiority in religious cosmology, theology, and social life, superscripted over a dynamic role as fiscally successful actors,”⁴⁸ its critical vocabulary romanticizes the fear and trauma of the twelfth-century Jewish community at Lincoln when it found itself in a moment of great vulnerability because of racialized accusations. Heng sets the scene following the discovery of the drowned corpse of Hugh, a Christian boy who had gone missing; in that moment the Jewish community realizes that it will collectively be inculpated for what was then and there seen as the uniquely Jewish crime of kidnapping and killing Christian children:

The panicked behavior of the Jews who were gathered in Lincoln for the marriage of Belaset, daughter of Benedict fil’ Moses, poignantly expresses the sense of danger and fragility that characterized the quotidian existence of a minority community used to periodic violence from the majority population among which the minority community lived, and by which it was surrounded.⁴⁹

Overriding my interest in any other detail or broad stroke found in this section, the only thing I wanted to know was this, as I recoiled while reading: From whose perspective is the palpable fear felt within the Jewish community of Lincoln *poignant*? For any population to live in regular, well-founded fear of exile and death now or then is anything but poignant to those implicated; it ought to be, too, to their allies and accomplices, medieval, modern-scholarly, and otherwise. In her monograph on the narratives of host desecration accusations against medieval Jews, Miri Rubin shows that viewing the poignancy of the Jews’ status in these narratives is a way of viewing them as weak relative to Christians and as a categorical other: “Within this context Jews were to acquire a poignant identity, as this benign discourse, which crystalized in the twelfth century into a formidable repertoire, embraced the Jew as the opponent of the Virgin’s grace, but also as a needy recipient of her mercy.”⁵⁰ Where Rubin uses the concept of poignancy to reflect the position of Jewish identity in the European Middle Ages, Heng adjudicates the behavior of these Jews to be poignant. For her to reflect and, in effect, sign on to this characterization of the

48 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 62.

49 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 28.

50 Rubin, *Gentile Tales*, 7.

situation of the Jews of Lincoln is to make a spectacle of their suffering and challenge the full humanity of the situation in which they find themselves. To be blunt, my fellow left-leaning colleagues in medieval studies whose legitimate interests in social justice extend into the modern world would never describe the abuse of a terrorized or oppressed contemporary population in these terms, but Heng appears to have no qualms about casting her medieval subjects as such.⁵¹ And this is precisely the kind of slip to which I refer when I argue that adopting a position of critical compassion ultimately leads to more sound scholarship; if Heng were to have moved beyond the pitying conclusion that the suffering of Lincoln's Jews was "poignant," if she had sought to understand that fear rather than merely gawk at it, what greater depth might her analysis have achieved?

A veritable inquisitorial metaphor suggests itself in the examples outlined above, in which Heng is ferreting the Jews out of history, joining her medieval English subjects in passing judgment on the sincerity of their conversions, and insisting upon a Christian framing for their lives within history. In fact, this is a recognized historiographical pitfall identified by Carlo Ginzburg in the final essay of his *Clues, Myths, and the Historical Method*:

While reading inquisitorial trials, I often felt as if I was looking over the judges' shoulders, dogging their footsteps, hoping (as they presumably did) that the alleged offenders would talk about their beliefs—at the offender's own risk, of course. This proximity to the inquisitor somewhat contradicted my emotional identification with the defendant. A different kind of contradiction can be experienced on the intellectual level. The inquisitors' urge for truth (their own truth, of course) has produced for us extremely right evidence—deeply distorted, however, by the psychological and physical pressures which played such a powerful role in witchcraft trials.⁵²

In other words both the anthropologist and the historian run the risk of pursuing truth and interpretation along the same methodological lines as the denizens of the Inquisition; in this instance, Heng's proximity to the sources that describe and construct Jewish race from the perspective of those advocating for conversion means that, while looking over their shoulders she comes to adopt their position even though it is clear, as Ginzburg describes, that her

51 And, indeed, Rubin goes as far as to describe these circumstances as a "narrative of abuse" (3).

52 Carlo Ginzburg, "The Inquisitor as Anthropologist," 141–8.

identification (whether emotional or intellectual) is meant to lie with the converted subject. To be sure, this is a fine needle to thread: I am not suggesting that Heng is advocating for the conversion of medieval Jews but rather that her perspective on conversion is so informed by her knowledge of the Christian sources that form the basis of her textual corpus that she cannot disentangle the polemical vision of the category creation from its impact. Heng adopts a medieval, clerical, and purely theoretical attitude toward conversion, ignoring the current scholarly approaches to the topic that are more suited to explaining the wide range of causes and effects of the phenomenon of religious conversion. By suggesting that possible outcomes might include clarity and acceptability, and by holding that interior belief and individual choice are the ultimate markers of conversion, she adopts the position of the medieval inquisitor.⁵³

3 Naming Names to the Inquisition

For the purposes of comparison with the English (or “European”) situation, Heng draws the Jews of Spain, who did in fact face an Inquisition, into her analysis in *The Invention of Race*. The most important postcolonial and critical race theorists write in some degree of unison about the importance of the correct reception, transmission, and representations of the names of a scholar’s subjects; recently, for example, the theorist Kimberlé Crenshaw has written about the impact of publicizing the names of individual Black, female victims of police violence in order to emphasize the impact of the state on the lives of women; and in the more literary universe, many postcolonial writers have explored the impact of having to change their names to be legible in the colonial language rather than in their own home language.⁵⁴ This is a useful framework to keep in mind when writing about medieval subjects who found themselves at the wrong end of nascent state power; and so, to represent names in a

53 For more current scholarly methodologies of assessing the history of conversions and a broader discussion of what history-writing can and cannot assess about the motives of converts, their beliefs, and their daily lives before and after their conversions, see the introductions to monographs by Harvey Hames (*The Art of Conversion*) and Ryan Szpiech (*Conversion and Narrative*). A forthcoming University of Pennsylvania Press book by Paola Tartakoff will also address these issues in detail and against the grain.

54 Kimberlé Crenshaw, Andrea Ritchie, et al. *Say Her Name*. One example of this is the short story by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie entitled “The Headstrong Historian” first published in *The New Yorker* in 2008. For a discussion in theoretical terms, see: Regina Austin, “Sapphire Bound!” and Charles R. Lawrence III, “The Word and the River,” in *Critical Race Theory: The Key Writings*.

convenient, often Anglicizing, and sometimes outright erroneous, way rather than in accordance with the subject's own practices and pronunciations represents not only a mistake but marks a lack of respect and critical compassion for the object of the scholar's study.

Beginning with a hegemonic onomastics, the historian-as-inquisitor model (for Ginzburg ultimately includes history alongside anthropology as a discipline that can tend toward the inquisitorial) defines Heng's treatment of the Jews of medieval Spain and their descendants, not just those of England. She compares her analysis of forcibly-converted Jews in England to forcibly-converted Jews in Spain, a population referred to in primary sources and in both English- and Spanish-language scholarship as *conversos*, meaning converted people. It is a name still in use today, not only to write about medieval populations of converted Jews but also their descendants, many of whose families have maintained Judaizing traditions (like lighting candles at home on Fridays without further ritual) and whose communities have moved recently to begin to reclaim their heritage as the descendants of forcibly converted Jews.⁵⁵ Converso identity is also becoming a part of the national conversation in the United States as Latinx politicians, including Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, share family histories that include *conversos*, and in Spain with the vagaries of new citizenship laws that apply to the descendants of Jews expelled in 1492..⁵⁶ In short, the *conversos* were and are a particular subaltern population. Yet Heng consistently names them not *conversos* but *conversi*, a choice that is not just an attempt at a needlessly showy, Latinizing flourish, but in fact an error that conflates the Jewish *conversos* of Spain with *conversi*, or lay brothers in English Cistercian orders.⁵⁷ To quibble about their name may seem like a small point; but it isn't. For a book that is grounded in the principle of decolonizing scholarship of the Middle Ages, mis-naming a population like this falls far short of the book's own goals and principles. To write about *conversi* rather than *conversos*

55 A pathfinding anthropological study on the *converso* communities of the American southwest is Seth Kunin, *Juggling Identities*. See also Stanley Hordes. *To the Ends of the Earth*. Other takes on the phenomenon make innovative use of media and narrative techniques to convey both anthropological and historiographic ideas, including Ilan Stavans's *El Iluminado*; and Cary Herz, *New Mexico's Crypto-Jews*.

56 Isaac Stanley-Becker, "Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez Reveals Jewish Ancestry at Hanukkah Celebration"; and Ashley Passmore, "Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez' Sephardic Story is One Forgotten By White Jews."

57 On the *conversi*, see Janet Burton and Julie Kerr, "Conversi, Granges, and the Cistercian Economy," chapter seven of *The Cistercians in the Middle Ages*; Christopher Cannon, "Monastic Productions"; and Constance Berman, "The Profits of Grange Agriculture," chapter four of *Medieval Agriculture, the Southern French Countryside, and the Early Cistercians*, 61–92.

looks at first glance like nothing more than a tiny typographical error but in fact contains a whole Anglicizing, colonial world.⁵⁸ It imposes the terminology of a Christian population of medieval England upon a population of medieval Jews and an English name upon them and upon their descendants who still live in Spanish-speaking territory in the United States and Mexico. This is no decolonization of the Middle Ages but rather a colonization anew.⁵⁹

58 It also raises the question of how familiar the author is with the scholarship on the *conversos* and the sources that document their lives that such a mistake could have found its way into her book and remained there in multiple locations.

59 The Muslim subjects of this work face the same treatment. Case in point is that of the figure, in history and literature, of the Ayyubid sultan Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn, whom Heng both mis-contextualizes in terms of racial and ethnic categories as they functioned in their historical context and misnames in ways that blur the lines between her discussion of the historical figure and the medieval European literary representations of him. In the first matter, Heng introduces him simply as a “Kurdish emir” (56), which seems to encode modern assumptions about the place of Kurds in present-day Iraq and Turkey and their late racialization there (see Egin), while ignoring medieval discourses on race and ethnic origin in the Islamic world and, crucially, the power dynamics preceding the foundation of the Ayyubid sultanate and those that prevailed during its rule in Egypt—or at a minimum does not provide the reader with enough context to understand why his Kurdish origins are significant in how he is represented in medieval European sources. In the second matter, where Heng refers to both Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn and his predecessor, Nūr al-Dīn, in their instantiations as historical personages rather than literary personae, she renders the former’s name as “Salah ad-Din” (Righteousness of the Faith), approximating a transliteration of the *laqab* (formulaic sobriquet) of the historical figure, but uses Nuraldin, the Anglicized, literary version of his predecessor, whose name would be rendered in parallel as Nūr al-Dīn (Light of the Faith). In other words, in referring to the historical figures rather than the medieval English literary representations of them, if you’re going to “Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn,” then you need to “Nūr al-Dīn,” too. To give one name as a variation on Ṣalāḥ al-Dīn and the other as Nuraldin resonates as the scholarly equivalent of the moment in the Crusades-themed Hollywood blockbuster, *Kingdom of Heaven* (Ridley Scott, 2005), when Saladin meets Balian on the field of battle after taking Jerusalem and pronounces his name in an over-exaggerated fashion that is completely out of line with the pallid representations of Muslims throughout the rest of the film. In fact, so many examples of botched and inconsistent use of Arabic names and terms that one can only conclude that they are there as only the most superficial attempt at inclusivity and globality, which in turn contributes to the Orientalizing, colonialist character of the work. Heng’s kind of linguistic carelessness does the work of othering the subject in the way that Jonathan Z. Smith describes in his “Differential Equations on Constructing the Other”: “The model where the ‘other’ is represented linguistically and/or intellectually in terms of intelligibility, admits no ... ambivalence. Here, the ‘other’ remains obdurately ‘other’ in a most basic sense: the ‘other’ is unintelligible and will remain so” (237). In short, misspelling and misrepresenting Arabic names and words represents Arabic speakers and writers as mere babblers and scribblers, contributing to their othering just as much as the modern author’s medieval counterparts do.

In his lyric short essay, “Yo, judío,” the Argentine author Jorge Luis Borges illustrates the importance of precision in naming names and in drawing conclusions from them. He composed the in sardonic response to⁶⁰ the accusations made against him by the far-right *nacionalista* magazine *Crisol* that he

This is a serious charge, particularly amongst scholars of Arabic, who are notoriously stringent about this kind of detail, and so I will offer an additional example of Heng’s linguistic carelessness, which has the effect of asserting the superiority and centrality of English over other languages of the world. Heng writes the name of the Syrian site of a 1098 Crusade battle, *Ma’arrat al-Nu’mān*, as “Ma’arra an-Numan” (120). Some of the differences between the way I have rendered the toponym here and the way that she has rendered it are due to differences in preferred transliteration systems. Thus, the *l* in the definite article *al-* in *al-nu’mān* reflects the written spelling of the word while its replacement with an *n* in the definite article in Heng’s rendering, *an-numan*, reflects the pronunciation when spoken aloud. The *t* present in my transliteration but missing from hers reflects the written spelling rather than the pronunciation of the toponym in bound form. The missing macron, too, reflects a choice to omit all vowel-length markers which is sometimes done to de-clutter the text for non-specialist readers. None of this is problematic. However, other parts of the toponym as she renders it are simply incorrect. By using the left-facing apostrophe in the word *ma’arra* instead of a right-facing one, and by omitting an apostrophe entirely in the word *nu’mān*, she misrepresents the consonantal structure of the word; that is to say, she misspells both parts of the toponym. The correct spelling of the place-name in Arabic characters is *معرة النعمان* whereas Heng’s transcription represents the Arabic characters *مأرة النمن*. Even those readers who cannot read the Arabic will be able to see from the shape of the consonantal skeleton of the words that these are two distinct toponyms, the real one and the invented one backformed from the erroneous transliteration that reflects a true misspelling of that toponym rather than “just” a stray diacritical point. To give an example in the parlance of the book’s medieval English literature audience, this spelling of the toponym includes a mistake as serious as would be using the letters *wynn* and *thorn* interchangeably and indiscriminately in one’s transcription of Old English words and sometimes randomly adding or omitting them. A hugely positive development of the interest in a more global Middle Ages is that it has, likewise, sparked an increased interest in world languages; however, they cannot simply be treated as a kind of window-dressing to signal that the scholar is, in principle, interested in other parts of the world, which is, in effect, what happens here. Simplified transliteration systems are completely fine to use; but a system that is not a system but rather a jumble of symbols that make transcribed words and especially personal and place names look a bit more “Arabicky” do a service to no-one and instead demonstrate yet again that it is acceptable within the neo-colonial decolonial English-medieval theoretical framework of this book to disregard the languages of colonized/subject peoples real or imagined.

60 The real bite of the essay comes at the end, when Borges alludes to the inquisitorial tendencies manifest both by himself and *Crisol*: “Statistically, the Hebrews are among the smallest in number. What would we think of a man who, in the year 4000, were finding residents of San Juan everywhere he looked? Our inquisitors look for Hebrews but never Phoenicians, Scythians, Babylonians, Persians, Egyptians, Huns, Vandals, Ostrogoths, Ethiopians, Dardanians, Paphlagonians, Sarmatians, Maidos, Ottomans, Berbers, Britons, Libyans, or Melanesians. The nights of Alexandria, Babylon, Carthage, Memphis never

had “Jewish roots, maliciously hidden.” He explains that the accusations of Judaizing made against him came about because the second part of his bi-partite surname is one that traditionally belonged to Portuguese-Jewish immigrants to Argentina:

My name is Borges Acevedo. Ramos Mejía, in a certain footnote in the fifth chapter of *Rosas and His Age*, lists all of the *porteño* family names from that time in order to demonstrate that all of them, or almost all of them, “come from a Hebreo-Portuguese stratum.”⁶¹ Acevedo appears in that catalogue: the only proof of my pretensions to Judaism until *Crisol* confirmed it.⁶²

In other words, as much as “it has not displeased me to think that I might be Jewish,”⁶³ he could find no such ancestry for himself and ultimately confronts the reality of the ancestors that he sought but could not find (Cant. 3:2): “Two hundred years and no Israelites; two hundred years and that ancestor eludes me.”⁶⁴ Borges was condemned—in Buenos Aires in 1934—as a secret Jew by virtue of not being possessed of an Old Christian family name just as he might have been four-and-a-half centuries earlier. Naming names and wielding them mattered then and then, and it matters now.⁶⁵

conceived a single ancestor. Only the tribes of the bituminous Dead Sea were given this gift.”

61 With Borges having been the writer he was, it is worth mentioning that this footnote does exist as cited: José María Ramos Mejía. *Rosas y su tiempo*, 136.

62 Jorge Luis Borges, “Yo, judío,” 89. Translation mine.

63 Borges, “Yo, judío,” 89.

64 Borges, “Yo, judío,” 90.

65 Another curious example of the elision of names and foreign words occurs in Heng’s discussion of Wolfram von Esenbach’s *Parzival*, in which she makes the claim that this text illustrates “slippage between thinking about Muslims and thinking about Jews” when it “refers to the Caliph of Baghdad as ‘the Baruch’ of Baghdad, as if the leaders of infidel Abrahamic communities were interchangeably alike” (55). This claim rests upon several erroneous foundational principles: first, that the Hebrew word “*baruch*,” blessed, was used as a leadership title by medieval Jewish communities; and second, that Hebrew or Arabic words could be transposed perfectly into romances written in European languages; however, this does not reflect the ways in which Hebrew or Arabic words are typically transposed into medieval European vernaculars, a process in which they are adapted for local phonology and often end up incorporating a certain degree of error in transmission. And so, if Heng wishes to sustain the argument that a Hebrew word was transposed fully correctly to represent an Arabo-Islamic political concept (rather than this representing an incidence of what linguists call pernicious homophony, or two words coming to sound the same by coincidence after developing from different etymological origins and through different processes of linguistic change), the history of that word within its

4 Voices, Sources, and Methodologies

When I return in my mind's eye to my student's reaction to Judah Halevi and the idea that she might be held to account for his—what many scholars are comfortable calling, although it has not gained wide traction in the field⁶⁶—racism, I cannot but bring it into dialogue with the personal anecdotes with which Heng opens *The Invention of Race*, first, an incident at the International Medieval Congress at Leeds in 2017⁶⁷ and second, a particular critique of her work by

a white, male English medievalist from London, at a metropolitan university in the heart of the old British Empire [who] decided that my literary practice of reading, which he labeled “postcolonial” was inadequate and inadequately “postcolonial” unlike the practice of many of my colleagues, because I had not sufficiently promoted the paramount importance of medieval French—the lingua franca of the European Middle Ages.⁶⁸

Both of these anecdotes ask readers to think about the subject position not only of our medieval actors and writers, but of ourselves and our colleagues as scholars. Heng comments upon the different ironies and outrages of these situations, and follows with a question: “Who gets to speak for us?”⁶⁹

It is a crucially important question that ultimately does not loom nearly as large as it ought to in a book on the construction of racial identity through external categorization and representation; and it is certainly one that is not raised vis-à-vis the book's, and the medieval English majority's, Jewish subjects. Heng does not speak well for them nor, through her deliberate methodological

European literary context and its transmission to there must be traced out much more fully. This is yet another example of a potentially fascinating claim that could be powerfully supportive of the overall argument being dropped into the text of the work but then never actually borne out through textual evidence.

66 Because of the structural nature of racism and the fact that Halevi, while well-connected, did not occupy a position of power that would have allowed him to act upon or benefit from his prejudices within a system that reinforced or undergirded them, my tendency is to think of Halevi's ideas about race as racial/religious prejudice rather than racism per se. I am joined in this choice and the rationale that gets me there by many of my colleagues, while other scholars make this same choice but on different and sometimes less theoretically-informed grounds. For further on the structural and institutional nature of racism, see Ibram X. Kendi, *How To Be an Anti-Racist*, 17–19.

67 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 13.

68 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 2.

69 Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 2.

choices, does she facilitate the potential for them ever to speak for themselves through the din of the majority culture that invented them as a race. Instead, she is satisfied to write:

The historical record is silent because though English Jewish might have spoken, they were not heard. What *are* heard are the accusations against them: What speaks more loudly than the documentary marks in pipe rolls is the popular communal lie of child murder that predetermined the fate of Lincoln's Jews and foreordained their death. In their inability *to speak and be heard*—in their silencing by church, state, and populace—we see the subalternizing of England's Jews, the racial subalterns of the medieval West. Their subalternity conferred by their inability to be heard, again and again, over the lies told about them, these racial subalterns are spoken for, and spoken about, by the structures of power ranged against them. The creation of England's Jews as raced subjects, and as racial subalterns are mutually constitutive moments.⁷⁰

Again, I read in this passage not only a medieval population creating a subaltern out of a religious minority in its midst but also the author's complicity with that historical process and the disquieting ease with which she walks away from the problem, abdicating historiographical responsibility. Although *The Invention of Race* is, of course, fundamentally a book about outsider attitudes toward minority populations—that is to say, the imposition of racial categorization by powerful and outside observers rather than the self-conception of those minority populations—when she does raise the issue of Jewish voices in the sources, she does not avoid analyzing them because it falls outside of the scope of her study, but rather, she claims, because they are unrecoverable.

The challenge of understanding the representation of minority populations and recuperating their voices has been developed fairly substantially in other fields of history, and medievalists could profitably benefit from considering and adapting those methodologies. Scholars of the early modern Atlantic and Mediterranean worlds, which, are not so easily separable from the Middle Ages as they might seem to be, have extensively developed methodologies for writing about the lives of enslaved and illiterate people without excluding their perspectives from the analysis. For example, in the introduction to her *Dispossessed Lives*, Marisa Fuentes raises the question directly rather than foreclosing it: "How do we narrate the fleeting glimpses of enslaved subjects in the archives and meet the disciplinary demands of history that requires us

⁷⁰ Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 75, emphasis in the original.

to construct unbiased accounts from these very documents?"⁷¹ She begins to answer this and related questions by placing emphasis on the agency of various actors at is reflected or omitted in the documentary sources; by interrogating the relationships between slave-owning white women and enslaved black women; and by centering in her analysis the limited representation of the latter group within those archival materials or, in her words, "productively mining archival silences and pausing at the corruptive nature of this material"⁷² and "paying attention to ... archival imbalances [that] illuminate systems of power and deconstruct the influences of colonial construction of race, gender, and sexuality on the sources that inform our work."⁷³ Finally, she adjures her readers to consider the problem proactively: "What would it mean to be critical of how our historical methodologies dependent upon such sources often reproduce these silences?"⁷⁴ And within Medieval Studies, even within the English orbit, Nicholas Howe writes to the same ends about solving "the interpretive problem of the void"⁷⁵ by reading literary texts in conjunction with documentary and material evidence in order to more fully illuminate the panorama of possible postcolonial interactions in medieval England. Even though the purpose of *The Invention of Race* is not to chronicle medieval Anglo-Jewish self-conception, it is deceptive to suggest that such an analysis would not be possible; to do so reinforces the idea that medieval Jews are only subjects to be classified from the outside—to be racialized. History-writing and literary criticism have developed toolkits to work through this kind of problem of missing or silent sources, but they do not seem to enter into play here.

This returns us to the questions, which lurk below the surface of the present essay, about disciplinary boundaries and the ways in which interdisciplinarity can and can't serve this kind of scholarship. It is clear that an interdisciplinary approach is necessary to a topic as complex as race-making in the Middle Ages, one that has room for religious-, cultural-, and social-historical; literary; and anthropological methodologies. Yet in spite of the author's self-proclaimed efforts at interdisciplinarity, this work ultimately does not transcend disciplinary boundaries, nor does it use single-disciplinary frameworks to their best effect. In a laudable attempt to be truly interdisciplinary, Heng in fact narrowed down her toolkit in ways that silence the subjects whose voices she claims not to be able to hear. The ways in which disciplinary boundaries are

71 Fuentes, *Dispossessed Lives*, 1.

72 Fuentes, *Dispossessed Lives*, 5.

73 Fuentes, *Dispossessed Lives*, 6.

74 Fuentes, *Dispossessed Lives*, 5.

75 Howe, "Anglo-Saxon England and the Postcolonial Void," 26.

wielded and adhered to precisely in the service of interdisciplinary analysis—counterintuitively and, ultimately, ineffectively—also do not facilitate a more fruitful resolution of this question. Heng’s academic background and scholarship hew more closely to the disciplinary practices of literary criticism than to those of history; and in an attempt to ensure the interdisciplinarity of the work she tries to sublimate the materials and methods of her “home” discipline. Returning to the introduction of the volume we see Heng’s methodological statement about the kinds of sources her work will consider:

Necessarily, the book investigates the materialization of race and racisms through different kinds of critical attention. You will find a variety of formal approaches and styles in the pages below because of the variety of subjects the book treats. This means that ... *The Invention of Race* is not a volume of readings of literature as such, with comprehensive bibliographies of literary scholarship (apologies, therefore, to those in search of literary criticism and literary bibliographies per se). The book tries not to privilege literature over all other disciplines (especially as literature is my home discipline), and only analyzes literary texts when these are the documents most trenchantly apposite to the discussion of race—when they are the fittest and most revealing exemplars of racial terrain.

As often as not, with guidance from the scholarship of economic historians and art historians, historical sociology and anthropology, and religious studies, *The Invention of Race* works to retrieve the economic and social relations between ethnoracial groups; grasp the politics of international war, colonizing expeditions, and commercial trade; unravel the meaning of iconic artifacts of phenomena ... or calibrate from eyewitness and other accounts the West’s understanding of global ethnoracial relations in macrohistorical time.⁷⁶

In other words, Heng sets out to write a historical work rather than a work of literary-critical scholarship. However, by virtue of the low priority it places upon contextualization within time and place and the changes that can take place across those contexts, it is hard to regard it as a work of history per se. Its selection and treatment of source materials is, perhaps inescapably, that of a scholar of literature; simply trying to deprioritize literary sources does not a historical or an interdisciplinary work yield.

And while Heng nominally distinguishes between literary and historical sources, she does not define or engage with the nature of those categories,

⁷⁶ Heng, *The Invention of Race*, 5–6.

something that even the hardest-line social historians have come around to recognizing the need to discuss. And so, while she does deal with certain texts that one might easily classify as literary, such as Mandeville's *Travels*,⁷⁷ she seemingly classifies such texts as purely historical writing; and in the chapter on the racialization of the Jews of England, she refuses to turn to the literary sources that would have helped to address some of the archival silences. This is not just a desire not to privilege the literary that Heng expresses in her introduction, but rather a case of needlessly ignoring literary sources for the sake of ignoring them, even when they could be leveraged into the historiography.⁷⁸ Literary sources, too, can be used for the writing of history; this is one of the greatest strengths of the subfields of cultural and literary history. These kinds of sources aren't mutually exclusive, and when there isn't much, it seems that one ought to take what one can get rather than concluding that the subaltern could not speak audibly. In sum, she does not use the methodologies of historical inquiry but also does not use the evidence that literary study would pursue. As a consequence, rather than being interdisciplinary, the study simply falls short.

5 Conclusion

In the end, I return to Heng's question: *Who gets to speak for us?* And I take a step further back: Who is "us"? Who are we as medievalists, in relationship to our colleagues, and in relationship to our subjects in light of our own contemporary identitary commitments? What does it mean, especially for moving forward in writing about race, for an author to claim positionality as a postcolonial subject as a foundational rhetorical move in her theory and her work (as Heng does in the introductory pages of the work) and then recolonize so many

77 John Mandeville. *The Book of Marvels and Travels*. We see elsewhere, too, that Heng is inclined to take travel writing as purely historical, even though it is not totally warranted. Elsewhere she describes the Jewish travel writer Benjamin of Tudela as "no fabulator" (131) in order to shore up the veracity of his description of the Nizari enclaves described in his *Journeys*; yet scholars have shown that the farther east Benjamin travels, the more fabulous and invented his accounts become, until they reach the point of legend rather than log; see references to articles by Jacobs, Fauville-Aymar, and Shalev in the bibliography of the present essay, as well as Adler's introduction to the turn-of-the-century text edition. This is yet another example of her misuse of Jewish writing against medieval Muslim subjects.

78 Foundational for this mode of thinking is Gabrielle Spiegel's "History, Historicism, and the Social Logic of the Text in the Middle Ages." My own thinking as a literary critic working in a historical mode has also been furthered by William Sewall's *The Logics of History*.

of her own subjects in the medieval subaltern? Can any scholar ever truly empathize with her subject when it is so distant in time and space? And if so or if not, how do we account for the ways in which our own identities as scholars creep into and inform our own work? Perhaps the question is not *who gets to speak for us?*, but rather, *how do we read those who do speak?*.

Scholars who have written earlier about race and the racialization of religion in the Middle Ages and in early modern Europe have reflected upon their own identity commitments and the relationship of those commitments to their scholarship. For example, Miri Rubin considers the challenges of writing about medieval anti-Semitism in contemporary Europe:

The challenges posed by this book have been legion: those faced by any historian of the Middle Ages but many more. There was the constant struggle in the face of the consoling allure of pat generalizations about Christianity, about human nature, about Germans. There was the compelling feeling of personal involvement when touching headstones or reading texts in Hebrew, when thinking of all the different ways in which memory and fear coalesce into contemporary historical consciousness. There was the cruel beauty of places which change little, where a chapel still stands proud since its erection in the late Middle Ages on the site of a synagogue destroyed following a host desecration accusation, testimony to the dramatic buffeting of a Jewish community in a place which presents itself as so little touched by time. But there has also been the beauty of history and the few glowing examples of humane doubt and courage by medieval people which make us appreciate more recent examples of resistance.⁷⁹

And more recently, Jean-Frédéric Schaub writes even more explicitly about the same subject:

I have to clarify what my own historical and social coordinates are. Born, raised, and trained in France, I am a French citizen of second generation by my father's side and third by my mother's side, both of them having come from Jewish families, one of which migrated to France from Poland, and other from Germany, before World War II. There is, of course, a direct link between my interest in racial issues and the memory of the Holocaust that has been central in shaping my personality. Knowing this, I do not interpret the whole history of the West as a long-term preparation of the

79 Rubin, *Gentile Tales*, 6.

final disaster of the Third Reich.⁸⁰ My approach to political processes of early modern and contemporary eras depends upon my anchorage in the European experience, particularly France. I admit, but only to a certain extent, the argument that only those who have experienced some type of phenomenon are able to transcribe it, but not that only a certain type of people is capable of understanding the transcript. My experience in France taught me that there was not necessarily a difference between a Jewish sensibility and a non-Jewish sensibility concerning the memory of the Holocaust.⁸¹

For all the similarities that do exist between the medieval and modern worlds, we medievalists are all necessarily non-medievals; and so it is up to us to understand the “transcript” of the Middle Ages with both the academic and personal tools that are available to us. Schaub’s take in particular is a heartening encouragement that the task is an achievable one. But it requires a fully informed appreciation of the different types of colonial and imperial thinking that informed the creation of our field and the ways in which they hide in the most basic tools of our trade: our fundamental assumptions and the language we use to express them. Heng’s book doesn’t fail because it is trying to tear down a long-standing academic artifice, but rather because it doesn’t tear it down all the way to the foundations and instead rests itself upon them.

Ultimately, the book’s undoing is its twofold: its magpie approach to interdisciplinarity and its lack of a commitment to the material that a critical-compassionate approach would demand. Ultimately it lacks the fingertip sensitivity to text and context that come with immersive study. In its shortcomings, *The Invention of Race* demonstrates the real challenges of interdisciplinarity in literary and historical research. It argues, on the one hand, for how vital that kind of interdisciplinary work can be, but on the other hand serves as a cautionary tale against going it alone and, simply put, against doing it badly or half-heartedly. Heng’s treatment of religion and religious history as racialized categories is a prime example of the volume’s shortfalls; the work does not reflect a panoramic understanding of Jewish or Islamic history, of the interactions of those groups with Christian populations and their mutual constitutions, nor of the role of Christianity in shaping the narrative. Heng’s proposed kind of history, which is so necessary, requires interdisciplinary

80 It is worth noting that Schaub here positions himself in contrast to the late Inquisition historian Benzion Netanyahu, who casts a racialized hatred of Jews as a single thread running through the course of history, wrapping itself around events as diverse as the Spanish Inquisition and the Holocaust.

81 Schaub, *Race is About Politics* 3–4.

scholarship and collaboration, but it also requires more care and more knowledge of the disciplines themselves, their histories, and their methodologies, than this work demonstrates. And because of these shortcomings, Heng inadvertently replicates the historical, intellectual, and social structures she sets out to critique. Rubin again cautions against the possibility of this epistemological error: "When an outsider—a medieval observer or a later historian—misunderstands or judges the actions of those who belong, that very criticism can be turned into proof of the difference which the tale endorsed and the violence sought to annihilate."⁸² To insist upon languages and specialist expertise is not simply gate-keeping, as it has become fashionable to claim, but rather it allows for both the fingertip sensitivity to the materials and, more important and less self-evident, for the fostering of scholarly empathy and critical compassion that is a foundational step in decolonizing the Middle Ages.

The most charitable reading of this book would be as a first foray into the creation of a new area of study within the medieval world. Heng's many earlier articles on the topic make this reading harder to justify, as does the proliferation of thoughtful work on race-making in the Middle Ages published both before and after Heng conceived of this work over a decade ago. The topic is important and Heng is to be commended for drawing a lot of attention to it; however, its deep flaws, even on its own terms, mean that *The Invention of Race* is not a book that would benefit from a second, revised edition. It cannot be built upon but must instead be totally rethought before the discussion can move forward.⁸³

6 Postscript

There is a caveat: Critiquing thinking on race and academic work that uses progressive theoretical models has become a regular hobby of the political right;⁸⁴ and I can hear the distorting echoes of those arguments in the distance, so

82 Rubin, *Gentile Tales*, 2.

83 Other work to consider in the meantime may be found the bibliography of the present essay, including those studies by Suzanne Conklin Akbari, Sara Lipton, David Nirenberg, Miri Rubin, and Elizabeth Wright; and, as noted earlier, depending upon how one periodizes the break between the medieval and the early modern, and depending upon which through lines and continuities one emphasizes, also useful for this endeavor is work on race and religion by Rebecca Goetz, L.P. Harvey, Saree Makdisi, Jean-Frédéric Schaub, and others.

84 Phillips-Fein, "How the Right Learned to Loathe Higher Education." See also the selection of essays in Louie Dean Valencia-García, *Far Right Revisionism and the End of History*.

often made in bad faith,⁸⁵ as I gesture toward the flaws in this book. Notable recent examples of this phenomenon have included the so-called “Sokal Squared Hoax,” in which three politically right-leaning academics spent a year writing fake papers based on fabricated data in fields that they deemed to fit under the umbrella of “grievance studies” in an attempt to prove that those fields—including anthropology, sociology, comparative literature (at least where post-colonial theory is concerned), and, notably, women’s and gender studies—are not intellectually rigorous⁸⁶ and are inclined to promote politically appealing ideas over intellectually sound ones;⁸⁷ and David Horowitz’s periodic lists of “dangerous” liberal professors;⁸⁸ not to mention the right-wing provocateur Milo Yiannapolous’s lengthy “exposé” of the field of Medieval Studies that, amongst its very many flaws, mostly substitutes the output of select, warring social media personalities for the intellectual work of the field at large.⁸⁹

85 On stylistic and philosophical fungibility in rhetoric on the political extreme right, see Nagle. *Kill All Normies*, 34–8.

86 Recently, Sierra Lomuto has written about some of the ways in which intellectual rigor and political progressiveness coexist: “Public Medievalism and the Rigor of Anti-Racist Critique.” It is worth noting that she, like Rajendran, reads Heng’s work rather differently than I do; while I disagree that *The Invention of Race* is an example of rigor in the service of progressive values, Lomuto’s argument is correct in its principles. In fact, my ultimate contention is that it is rigorous scholarship that best serves those values. There is no way to read the kinds of sources that we encounter in the study of the European Middle Ages (broadly construed) and believe honestly in a white supremacist analysis of the period.

87 Peter Boghossian, James Lindsay, and Helen Pluckrose, “Academic Grievance Studies and the Corruption of Scholarship.” It is worth mentioning that Portland State University has opened disciplinary proceedings against one of the authors, Boghossian, for academic fraud over his role in this experiment, as reported in the *Chronicle of Higher Education* on January 7, 2019: <https://www.chronicle.com/article/Proceedings-Start-Against/245431> (accessed 5/2019). Incidentally, Pluckrose recently delivered a talk (“The Problem with Grievance Studies”) about the hoax at the Ramsay Centre in Australia in which she argued that postmodernism represents a rejection of the Enlightenment and a return to medieval modes of thinking, based entirely on a set of utter falsehoods about intellectual inquiry in the medieval period. The original Sokal Hoax to which the “squared” epithet refers is outlined in Alan Sokal, *Beyond the Hoax*.

88 David Horowitz. *The Professors: The 101 Most Dangerous Academics in America*. The Southern Poverty Law Center describes Horowitz’s anti-academic activity: “Colleges and universities have been one of the main targets for Horowitz. His group is known for compiling McCarthyite lists of students, professors, and administrators and plastering campuses with posters accusing them of being subversive,” <https://www.splcenter.org/fighting-hate/extremist-files/individual/david-horowitz>, accessed 6/2019.

89 Milo Yiannapolous, “The Middle Rages: Why the Battle for Medieval Studies Matters for America.” Coverage in the popular press has tended to reduce questions of political commitment and the afterlife of scholarship to their manifestations in spats on social media that do not, it should go without saying, reflect the state of the field at large or the depth

Particularly where the Middle Ages is concerned, the consequences can be dire: most recently at the time of this writing, the shooter who massacred fifty Muslims at Friday prayers in a mosque in Christchurch, New Zealand, invoked the names of a variety of medieval figures he believed to underpin his vision of a racially pure, white Middle Ages; these figures included Charles Martel, Pelayo of Asturias, Urban II, and the Knights Templar, all juxtaposed against names and slogans of the modern architects of racist genocide, chief among them Adolf Hitler.⁹⁰ A turning point in the use of the Middle Ages to shore up white supremacy in immediate-contemporary political discourse was the “Unite the Right” rally in Charlottesville, Virginia, which saw right-wing protestors chanting racist and anti-Semitic slogans while donning garb marked with medieval-inspired iconography.⁹¹ These individuals use outmoded perceptions of medieval history to justify their own views of what their nations should look like; as Nadia Altschul explains: “Medievalist nationalism emphasizes the bond between scholars, their works, and the origins of their ‘own’ nation and language.”⁹² This is all to say that the Middle Ages is a powerful touchstone for contemporary right-wing thinkers and actors who like to believe that their vision of an all-white, Christian civilization has its historical roots in their very ahistorical vision of an all-white, nation-based Middle Ages. These nationalist fantasists, race-deniers, and wannabe fascists who see their imagined Middle Ages slipping away and turn their frustration and rage on the academy are *the* problem. They are the ones with the capacity to create an exclusive Middle Ages that exudes its racialized and religious violence into the public square of our own day.

But a book like Heng’s is *also a problem*. It introduces faulty assumptions and basic mistakes about Jews, Muslims, and other European religious and linguistic minorities to a field that is so hungry for a good and progressive treatment of race and religion in the Middle Ages that it is primed to take the work as authoritative regardless of the scope or nature of its flaws and errors. At the same time, those flaws and errors give cover to detractors who believe that race is not an appropriate topic for Medieval Studies to argue that such work is nonsensical and without real scholarly value. And, more gravely, it quietly

and nuance of the issues in play; for an example of this kind of coverage, see Jennifer Schlusser, “Medieval Scholars Joust with White Nationalists and One Another.”

90 English-language news outlets, such as the *Washington Post* and *Vice News*, tended to mention the inclusion of Charles Martel and Urban II, while Spanish-language news outlets, including *El País*, focused on the inclusion of Pelayo.

91 Josephine Livingston, “Racism, Medievalism, and the White Supremacists of Charlottesville.”

92 Altschul, *Geographies of Philological Knowledge*, 3.

encourages the unequal treatment of Jewish and Muslim subjects, current and historical, fostering an environment in which Jews and Muslims are still on the outside; and that ultimately supports the extreme right's conjoined historiographical and political goals. Radical, ahistorical, uncompassionate right-wing revisionism is a problem; but so, too, is radical, ahistorical, uncompassionate left-wing revisionism.

My own tradition, the religio-intellectual one that I share with my student who so quietly but vehemently disagreed with Judah Halevi's racialization of his own people—as well as hers and mine—suggests a way out, although it is not without its own complications. *Mesirah* is the act of one Jew bearing forbidden witness against another Jew in a non-Jewish court.⁹³ Defined as a potential death-penalty offense in the Talmud, rabbis and exegetes beginning in the second century of the Common Era and continuing through today have delineated a series of exceptions to this principle and guidelines that indicate when such an act of testimony is permitted;⁹⁴ in broad terms, these exceptions to the prohibition against *mesirah* cover those instances in which fair treatment of a Jewish accused can be assured and those in which the testimony before a non-Jewish court will clearly serve the interests of justice.⁹⁵ Within medieval Inquisitorial contexts, prosecutions before a Jewish court for *mesirah* were often ramped up and punishments harshly enforced because of the danger an informer could pose to involuntary converts suspected of rejecting their conversion and engaging in Judaizing practices.⁹⁶

This essay may be a form of liberal, secular, academic *mesirah*. I am bearing witness against a book in a form that will doubtless reach beyond the community with which I most closely identify: scholars of the Middle Ages who are invested not only in better understanding the medieval period for its own sake but in ensuring that its reverberations in the postmedieval world are not given over to evil. And while I may hope for the best and be certain that this is the correct and intellectually honest course of action, I know that to critique a work such as Heng's in the current political climate is, indeed, testimony

93 *Mesirah* is the act of testifying under these conditions, the *moser* or *moseret* is the (male or female) witness who testifies.

94 The prime contemporary example of this is the frequent (although not across the board) permission to give witness testimony in secular, state criminal courts against members of religious Jewish communities who are charged with the sexual abuse of minors.

95 Berman. *The Boundaries of Loyalty*; Lauer. *Colonial Justice and the Jews of Venetian Crete*; and, classically, Kaufmann, "Jewish Informers in the Middle Ages."

96 Ben-Shalom. "Kiddush-Hashem and Jewish Martyrology in Aragon"; Gampel. "Jews, Christians, and Muslims in Medieval Iberia," 23–4; Ben-Zimrah. "Slander and Informing in the Thinking of the Spanish Sages."

against one of my own that might, at least in the short term, harm the interests of justice by exposing weaknesses in a prominent example of the kind of scholarship that I believe has the potential, when done well, to serve both the Middle Ages and the present. It is my hope, though, that the exceptional act of writing and publishing a lengthy, negative review is ultimately worth it in the long term to short-stop this kind of neo-colonial, neo-Orientalist discourse that does damage to both the past and present before it becomes normalized within Medieval Studies; and that it will instead encourage that the racialization of medieval Jews and Muslims be studied in ways that account for what is lost when they are turned into archetypes and categories. The pursuit of fair and correct treatment of medieval Jewish and Muslim subjects and of their descendants, heirs, and students is itself, too, a just goal.

Ultimately I am optimistic: I am reminded almost daily by the work of so many of my colleagues that the study of the Middle Ages is a place for first-rate intellects;⁹⁷ and so there must be room, as F. Scott Fitzgerald would have had it, to hold both of those ideas—or, in the words of the twelfth-century philosopher and theologian Peter Abelard, *sic et non*: both this and that are wrong—and have them be held true without betraying anyone.

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97 The phrase comes from F. Scott Fitzgerald's essay "The Crack-Up": "The test of a first-rate intelligence is the ability to hold two opposed ideas in the mind at the same time, and still retain the ability to function." It was introduced into Medieval Studies by María Rosa Menocal to describe the literary culture of al-Andalus, very much for its Abelardian echoes: "It is about a genuine, foundational European cultural moment that qualifies as 'first-rate' in the sense of F. Scott Fitzgerald's wonderful formula ... In its moments of great achievement, medieval culture positively thrived on holding at least two, and often many more, contrary ideas at the same time" (*Ornament of the World*, 10–11).

to go beyond the short and descriptive to grapple with some of the bigger theoretical issues in the work under discussion and in the field as a whole. Particularly with regard to writing on a topic that is so potentially explosive, it is exceptionally important to stress that despite the encouragement and feedback I received from my colleagues, any flaws in the work are ultimately my responsibility and the result of my own readings and judgment calls.

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